1

India and the World

AN APOCRYPHAL STORY suggests that on his first day in office, every prime minister of modern India reads a letter on India's foreign policy ostensibly written by the country's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru. The letter starts with the words, 'Dear successor, many generations have passed since this letter was written but this letter is as valid for you today as it was for me and your other predecessors.' It goes on to list India's interests and concerns and outlines the parameters within which an Indian leader can formulate his country's foreign policy. The story about the imaginary letter demonstrates the abiding grip of history and tradition on the way India sees and interacts with the world.

With some variation, India's external relations have shown remarkable continuity and consistency since Independence in 1947, notwithstanding changes in leaders and ruling political parties. India is not alone in such constancy. Most countries base their foreign policy on a template shaped by their national experience and view of self. In India's case, its foreign policy paradigm borrows from its civilizational heritage as much as from modern ideas about national interest. Even when a policy idea appears new, it actually echoes one of several recurrent themes.